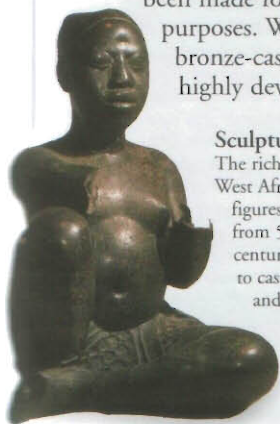


Art in Africa

African art has a long tradition, although a lack of written records make its history hard to trace. Sculpture and masks are major art forms. Most art seems to have been made for religious or ritual purposes. Wood-carving and bronze-casting techniques were highly developed.



Sculpture

The rich tradition of sculpture in West Africa begins with the pottery figures made by the Nok people from 500 BC. Around the 13th century AD the Ife of Nigeria began to cast outstanding bronze heads and figures in a highly realistic style. These may have influenced sculptures made in Benin, Nigeria, from the 16th to 19th centuries.

Ife sculpture, 13th century

Masks

African masks may represent a spirit or ancestor, or be purely decorative. Their meaning comes from the masquerade (dance, drama, and music) of which they are a part. Wood, beads, ivory, and shells are important materials. This capped mask, carved in a bold, vital style, is from Cameroon.



Wooden mask, 20th century

Asia

Traditionally in Asian art, the symbolic meaning behind the subject of a painting, sculpture, or carving is more important than the illusion of realism. In China, for instance, landscape paintings are stylized to express the ideals of religious thought: natural harmony, peace, and grace. In China and Japan, calligraphy was seen as a high form of art. The inscriptions are usually of short, poetic situations.



T'ang Yin, *Dreaming of Immortality in a Thatched Cottage*, Ming dynasty

Chinese landscape

In China, the art of painting developed from calligraphy. Landscape artists painted on paper or silk, using brush and ink. They did not paint from real life. The flow and vigour of the brush strokes were more important.

16th-century
Mughal
manuscript

Vividly
coloured
High
level of
detail

Brief poetic
description
of the scene



Miniatures

During the Mughal Empire (16th–17th centuries), figurative miniature painting flourished in India. These were richly coloured and exceptionally delicate. This illustration comes from a contemporary chronicle of the emperor's exploits.

Hokusai

Katsushika Hokusai (1760–1849) is perhaps the best-known Japanese printmaker. His famous wood-cuts include landscapes as well as scenes of daily life (called ukiyo-e). They are dramatically coloured and composed.

The Great Wave of Kawagawa, 1831



Native American art

Sophisticated Native American societies, such as the Aztec and Maya in Mexico and the Inca in Peru, created distinct artistic and architectural styles. Nearly 3,000 years ago, nomadic peoples in North and South America marked awe-inspiring "sculptures" on to the land, or created vast earthworks whose shapes can only be seen from high in the air.



Tlingit
totem
pole

Totem poles

Complex in design, and carved with great skill, totem poles showed the status of many Native North American chiefs.

Sand paintings

In the Southwest, Native North Americans trickled coloured sand and ground stones on to a smooth background to create temporary symbolic paintings with a ritual importance.



Navajo sand painting represents figures from Navajo mythology.

Easter Island statues

Between AD 400 and 1680, the people of Easter Island carved huge heads, up to 12 m (40 ft) high, from volcanic rock. They commemorate the divine ancestors of tribal chiefs.



Statues face
out to sea.

Statues,
Easter
Island

Pacific art

Contact with European Christian cultures from the 18th century onwards had a destructive effect on ancient local lifestyles in the Pacific islands. Much art has been lost, although some remarkable sculptures have survived, due to their durability. Wood and stone carvings, bark cloth paintings, spirit masks, and intricate body tattoos are among the important art forms of the Pacific area.

Timeline

30,000 BC Earliest known works of art produced.

30,000–10,000 BC Cave paintings made in France.

c.500 BC Lifelike human figurines produced by the Nok in West Africa.

100 BC–AD 300s

Roman empire spreads Classical art around Europe.

Warrior,
Greece,
520 BC



618–907 T'ang dynasty, China: great tradition of landscape painting develops.

15th century Beginning of the Renaissance in Europe.

16th century Mughal dynasty holds power in India.

17th century Dutch Golden Age of painting.

19th century Photography invented.

1860s–90s Impressionism develops in France. It is very influential.

Metal tubes are invented in the 1840s.

19th-century oil paints



20th century Time of incredible diversity of styles in the visual arts, including Cubism (1907–1920s), abstract art (1910–50), surrealism (1920s), and Pop Art (mid-1950s).

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